

THE CRUSADES

Throughout the crusading era (from 1095 to the fall of Acre in 1291), the weapons of the knights who formed the crusading elite remained relatively unchanged. The lance played a crucial part in the shock tactic of the mass charge, but at close quarters the sword was the crusader knight's most valuable weapon. Generally straight and double-edged, it was well adapted for use against mail. Later it was complemented in the Levant by daggers – considered unchivalrous in western Europe – and in the 13th century by axes, flails, and maces.

Extended quillons
curve towards blade

Silver
inlaid cross

Round pommel

▲ GERMAN SWORD

Date c.1100

Origin Northern Europe

Length 94cm (37in)

This heavy blade was typical of the swords used in the First and Second Crusades (1096–99 and 1147–49 respectively). It had a narrow edge, with wide quillons that curved towards the blade.

Straight, slightly
tapering quillons

▼ FIRST CRUSADE SWORD

Date c.1100

Origin Northern Europe

Length 99.5cm (39in)

The massive double-edged blade of this early 12th-century sword is typical of the weapons that would have been carried by knights on the First Crusade (1096–99).

Oval, conical
pommel

Double-edged
cutting blade

Fuller almost
reaches point

► DOUBLE-EDGED SWORD

Date 1150–1200

Origin Northern Europe

Weight 1.95kg (4¼lb)

Length 82.2cm (32¼in)

The blade of this heavy cutting sword was long and had two cutting edges. Its simple cross-guard, short hilt, and brazil-nut-shaped pommel are characteristic of 12th-century swords.

Wide, narrow cross

▲ EUROPEAN SWORD

Date Early 13th century

Origin Europe

Weight 1.2kg (2½lb)

Length 1m (3¾ft)

Common between the 10th and 14th centuries, swords known as “Type X” generally had wide blades with a brazil-nut-shaped pommel. They also had a narrower and longer cross-guard than preceding Viking types.

► NORTH EUROPEAN SWORD

Date 1280–1320

Origin Northern Europe

Weight 1.2kg (2½lb)

Length 91.4cm (36in)

Plate armour became increasingly common during the 13th century. As a consequence, swords with stiffer, pointed blades, better adapted to thrusting and exposing gaps in plate armour, were developed.

Pommel with horn-
like projections

Fuller tapers
off near point

Gently
curving quillons

▲ LATE “CRUSADER” SWORD

Date c.1270–c.1350

Origin France

Weight 1.45kg (3lb)

Length 74.5cm (29¼in)

Swords of the late crusading period typically had a flattened cone-shaped pommel with slightly curved quillons and a double-edged blade that tapered to a point. This example bears its maker's mark some 20cm (8in) up the hilt.